

THE SPIRITUALIST MOVEMENT

A COMPLETE DEEP DIVE

The Fox Sisters, Séance Culture, Lily Dale, Theosophy, and the Direct Line to the New Age

On the night of March 31, 1848,
in a small house in Hydesville, New York,
two girls asked a dead man to knock once for yes and twice for no.
He knocked.
Within ten years, millions of Americans and Europeans
were sitting in darkened rooms
waiting for the dead to speak.
The dead, it seemed, had a great deal to say.

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Introduction

The Moment That Changed Everything Hydesville, New York — March 31, 1848

The house at Hydesville, Wayne County, New York, was unremarkable in every physical respect — a small wooden farmhouse occupied since December 1847 by the Fox family: John Fox, his wife Margaret, and their two youngest daughters, Margaretta (Maggie), age 14, and Catherine (Kate), age 11. The previous tenant had left after complaining of unexplained nocturnal sounds — rappings and disturbances with no identifiable source.

On the night of March 31, 1848, Kate Fox addressed the sounds directly. 'Here, Mr. Splitfoot, do as I do,' she said — and clapped her hands. The sounds clapped back. Maggie snapped her fingers; the sounds snapped back. The girls established a code with the presence: one rap for yes, two for no. Through this code, the presence communicated that it was the spirit of a murdered peddler whose body was buried in the cellar. Excavations of the cellar in subsequent years produced human remains.

THE HYDESVILLE RAPPINGS — IMMEDIATE AFTERMATH

THE COMMUNITY RESPONSE: Neighbors gathered to witness the phenomenon. The rappings were experienced by dozens of independent observers over the following days — not just family members who might be suspected of fabrication, but unconnected members of the community who came specifically to investigate. THE SPREAD: Within weeks, the story had spread through New York State. Within months, it was national news. Within a year, the Fox sisters were giving public demonstrations to audiences of hundreds in Rochester and New York City. The rappings followed them — occurring in public venues, before skeptical audiences, in conditions designed to prevent fraud. THE CONFESSION AND ITS COMPLICATIONS: In 1888, Maggie Fox published a signed confession in the New York World claiming that the rappings had been produced by cracking the joints of their toes and knees — and demonstrated this technique on stage. The confession devastated the Spiritualist movement. However, a year later, Maggie recanted her confession, claiming it had been purchased from her by anti-Spiritualist interests. The question of what actually happened in Hydesville remains genuinely unresolved — not because the evidence is unclear, but because both the phenomenon's reality and the confession's reliability are contested.

Part Five

The Major Figures

Believers, Investigators, and Skeptics

The Spiritualist movement attracted engagement from some of the most important intellectual, literary, and scientific figures of the 19th and early 20th centuries — a fact that is consistently omitted from dismissive accounts of Spiritualism as mere superstition.

THE MAJOR FIGURES — COMPLETE

ARTHUR CONAN DOYLE (1859-1930): The creator of Sherlock Holmes — the most famous fictional rationalist in literature — was one of the most committed and most public believers in Spiritualism of his era. After losing his son Kingsley and his brother Innes in World War I, Doyle became convinced through séance communication that he had maintained contact with them. He wrote 'The History of Spiritualism' (1926), toured the world lecturing on the subject, and staked his considerable public reputation on the reality of spirit communication. His commitment was not credulous — he investigated extensively before accepting, and his acceptance was genuine, deeply felt, and never recanted. HARRY HOUDINI (1874-1926): The world's most famous escape artist and illusionist was also the most dedicated scientific skeptic of Spiritualist claims of his era. His motivation was not simple debunking — Houdini was desperately attempting to contact his deceased mother, whom he had loved profoundly, and was willing to believe if he could find one genuine medium. He never did. He exposed fraud after fraud — including the medium Mina 'Margery' Crandon, who had been endorsed by prominent scientists. His friendship with Conan Doyle, strained by their disagreements, is one of the most poignant intellectual relationships of the period. WILLIAM JAMES (1842-1910): The philosopher and psychologist — one of the founders of American psychology and the pragmatist philosophical tradition — co-founded the American Society for Psychical Research (ASPR) in 1885. James believed that the phenomena of Spiritualism deserved serious scientific investigation and that dismissing them without investigation was scientifically irresponsible. He investigated the medium Leonora Piper extensively over several years and concluded that 'the phenomena are real' while remaining uncertain about their ultimate explanation. LEONORA PIPER (1857-1950): The Boston medium whose work convinced William James — and the most extensively investigated medium in the history of psychical research. James hired private detectives to follow her, investigated her background for fraud, and subjected her sessions to rigorous observation over years. He could not account for her consistent accuracy about deceased persons she had no known way to have researched. FREDERIC MYERS (1843-1901): Cambridge scholar and co-founder of the British Society for Psychical Research. His posthumous work 'Human Personality and Its Survival of Bodily Death' (1903) remains one of the most serious scholarly treatments of the psychical research evidence.

Part Twelve

THE SÉANCE

Complete Historical Step-by-Step

The séance (from the French 'seoir' — to sit; literally 'a sitting') is the central ceremony of Spiritualist practice — the structured gathering in which a medium facilitates communication between living participants and the spirits of the deceased. The following step-by-step reflects historical séance practice as documented by investigators from the 1850s through the early 20th century.

THE SÉANCE — COMPLETE STEP-BY-STEP

PREPARATION: The medium selects or is provided with a private room. A round or oval table is preferred — no corners that could produce shadows or hiding places that skeptics might exploit. Chairs are arranged so that all participants can touch hands, creating an unbroken circle of human contact around the table. Lighting is reduced significantly — most historical séances were conducted in near-darkness or complete darkness, with a single red lamp as the exception. Darkness was understood by Spiritualists as creating the conditions under which spirit manifestations could form; skeptics understood it as covering fraud. Participants may be asked to sit for 30-60 minutes before the medium enters, singing hymns or sitting in silent expectation to build the group's 'spiritual atmosphere.'

THE SÉANCE ITSELF: STEP 1 — THE OPENING PRAYER: The medium or a designated leader opens with prayer — acknowledging the divine, requesting protection, and inviting only loving spirits to communicate. This opening prayer is the sacred threshold of the ceremony.

STEP 2 — THE CIRCLE IS FORMED: Participants join hands around the table. The instruction is typically to maintain contact throughout and not to break the circle — breaking the circle is understood as disrupting the conditions that allow spirit communication and in some traditions as potentially dangerous to the medium.

STEP 3 — CALLING THE GUIDE: Most developed mediums worked with a specific 'spirit guide' — a deceased person (often a Native American figure in American Spiritualism, or a historical figure) who served as the medium's intermediary with the spirit world. The medium calls the guide by name and waits for signs of the guide's presence.

STEP 4 — THE MANIFESTATIONS: Depending on the medium's specific gifts and the tradition of the séance, manifestations might include: rapping or knocking sounds responding to yes/no questions; table levitation (the table rising from the floor, experienced by participants as genuine); trumpet phenomenon (a metal trumpet moving through the darkened room, voices emerging from it); materialization (visible spirit forms, highly contested); direct voice (voices heard in the room distinct from the medium's voice); or the medium entering trance and speaking in another's voice.

STEP 5 — COMMUNICATION: Questions are asked of the spirits — typically through the guide first, who relays them. Responses come through rapping codes, through the medium's speech, or through written messages (see automatic writing). The most evidential communications provide specific information unknown to the medium that is subsequently verified.

STEP 6 — THE CLOSING: The medium signals the session's end — either because the guide announces that the communication is complete, or because the medium's energy is depleted. The circle is formally closed with prayer, thanking the spirits and formally releasing them. The room's lighting is restored gradually.

STEP 7 — THE RETURN: The medium, if they have been in deep trance, requires time to reorient to ordinary consciousness. Participants are advised not to rush the medium's return.

Automatic Writing Step-by-Step

Automatic writing — the practice of allowing the hand to write without the ordinary conscious mind directing it, with the intention that the writing expresses spirit communication — is one of the most widely practiced and most personally accessible of all Spiritualist and psychical techniques. Unlike the séance, which requires a medium and a group, automatic writing can be practiced alone.

AUTOMATIC WRITING — COMPLETE STEP-BY-STEP

WHAT IT IS: The practitioner holds a pen or pencil lightly on paper, enters a relaxed or meditative state, and allows the hand to move without conscious direction. The resulting writing is understood as potentially expressing content from the unconscious mind, from the practitioner's higher self, or from external spirit communication — depending on the practitioner's framework. **HISTORICAL CONTEXT:** Some of the most important Spiritualist communications were received through automatic writing — including the cross-correspondences studied by the SPR, in which different mediums in different locations produced interlocking fragments of a single complex message, suggesting coordination by an external intelligence. **STEP 1 — PREPARATION:** Sit at a table with paper and pen. The pen should be light and comfortable. Some practitioners prefer a planchette (a small wooden or plastic platform on casters with a pen attached) or a ouija board with a planchette — both are extensions of the same principle. **STEP 2 — ENTER RECEPTIVITY:** Breathe deeply and deliberately for several minutes. Allow ordinary conscious thinking to quiet. Do not try to blank the mind — simply allow thoughts to pass without following them. Some practitioners pray, invoke their guide, or state aloud that they are open to communication. **STEP 3 — HAND ON PAPER:** Rest the hand and pen lightly on the paper. Do not press. The hand should feel as though it is floating rather than resting. Maintain this position and the state of relaxed receptivity. **STEP 4 — ALLOW MOVEMENT:** When movement begins, do not try to read what is being written. Keep the eyes slightly averted or closed if possible. Conscious reading interrupts the flow by re-engaging the analytical mind. **STEP 5 — CONTINUE WITHOUT JUDGMENT:** Automatic writing typically begins as random marks or loops before becoming letters, then words, then coherent content. The transition from random marks to coherent content may take multiple sessions. Do not stop and analyze mid-session. **STEP 6 — THE CLOSING:** After 20-30 minutes, or when the movement stops naturally, formally close the session — a brief prayer or statement of closing that releases the connection and marks the return to ordinary consciousness. **STEP 7 — REVIEW:** Read what was written after full return to ordinary consciousness. Note what is recognizable as your own thought patterns and what feels genuinely different — in voice, in information, in character.

LILY DALE, NEW YORK

The Living Spiritualist Community

Lily Dale Assembly is a small community on the shores of Cassadaga Lake in western New York State — founded in 1879 as a Spiritualist summer camp, and still operating today as the oldest and largest Spiritualist community in the United States. Approximately 40 registered mediums live and work in Lily Dale year-round, and during the summer season (late June to early September), thousands of visitors arrive seeking spirit communication, healing, and connection with Spiritualist practice.

LILY DALE — WHAT IT IS AND WHAT HAPPENS THERE

THE COMMUNITY: Lily Dale's permanent population is small — approximately 275 residents, most of whom are registered Spiritualist mediums or affiliated practitioners. The community's Victorian-era houses are clustered on streets shaded by old trees. The atmosphere is deliberately preserved: no alcohol is sold within the gates, no commercial establishments operate inside the community, and the specific sacred character of the place is actively maintained. **THE STUMP:** The most iconic location at Lily Dale is the Stump — a large outdoor amphitheater built around a massive tree stump in a forest clearing. Twice daily during the summer season, registered mediums give public spirit messages at the Stump — standing before the assembled audience and delivering specific communications they receive to specific audience members. The Stump readings are free and open to all visitors. **PRIVATE READINGS:** Visitors can book private one-on-one sessions with registered mediums. These sessions vary by the medium's style — some work through clairvoyance (seeing), some through clairsaudience (hearing), some through psychometry (reading objects held by the sitter). The readings focus on connecting the sitter with deceased loved ones or providing guidance from spirit guides. **THE HEALING TEMPLE:** Lily Dale's Healing Temple offers free spiritual healing sessions during the season — practitioners work through laying on of hands, prayer, and specific energy healing methods to address the physical and emotional conditions of those who come. **THE LYCEUM:** The educational component of Lily Dale — workshops, lectures, and training programs in mediumship development, spiritual philosophy, and related practices. **HOW TO VISIT:** Lily Dale is open to the public during the summer season (approximately late June through Labor Day weekend). A gate fee is required for entry. Specific programs and readings require advance booking. The community's specific spiritual character is expected to be respected by all visitors — it is not a tourist attraction but an active spiritual community that welcomes visitors who approach with genuine respect.

The Direct Line

Spiritualism → Helena Blavatsky → Theosophy

The Theosophical Society was founded in New York City in 1875 by Helena Petrovna Blavatsky (1831-1891) and Colonel Henry Steel Olcott — emerging directly from the Spiritualist milieu of the 1870s as a more philosophically ambitious attempt to understand and systematize the phenomena that Spiritualism had been documenting.

HELENA BLAVATSKY AND THEOSOPHY — THE COMPLETE PICTURE

WHO BLAVATSKY WAS: Helena Blavatsky was a Russian-born traveler, occultist, and writer of extraordinary intelligence and controversial personal history. She arrived in New York in 1873, immediately involved herself in Spiritualist circles, and within two years had founded the Theosophical Society with the explicit goal of moving beyond the phenomena of Spiritualism toward a complete synthesis of world religions, occult philosophy, and the hidden wisdom she claimed to have received from a group of advanced spiritual beings she called the Mahatmas or Masters. **ISIS UNVEILED (1877) AND THE SECRET DOCTRINE (1888):** Blavatsky's two major works — both extraordinarily long and dense syntheses of Hinduism, Buddhism, Hermeticism, Kabbalah, and her own claimed received teachings — established the Theosophical framework that would directly influence every subsequent Western esoteric movement. The Secret Doctrine in particular introduced concepts (the Akashic Records, Root Races, cosmic evolution, the astral and other planes of existence) that became foundational vocabulary for the New Age movement a century later. **THE MAHATMAS CONTROVERSY:** Blavatsky claimed to receive teachings from physically remote but spiritually accessible Masters in Tibet — the Mahatma letters, some of which were 'precipitated' (appeared physically in closed locations). An 1884 investigation by the Society for Psychical Research concluded that the letters were fraudulent, produced through hidden compartments in a cabinet at the Theosophical headquarters. Blavatsky disputed this conclusion. The controversy was never definitively resolved. **THEOSOPHY'S LEGACY:** Despite the controversies, Theosophy's influence on Western spirituality is incalculable. It introduced Hindu and Buddhist concepts (karma, reincarnation, chakras, the higher self) to Western audiences decades before those concepts became widely known. It established the vocabulary and conceptual framework for virtually all subsequent Western esoteric movements.

Theosophy's Core Teachings

Akashic Records, Root Races, and the Astral Plane

The specific conceptual vocabulary that Theosophy introduced into Western spiritual culture has been so thoroughly absorbed that most contemporary practitioners use these concepts without knowing their Theosophical origin.

THEOSOPHY'S CORE CONCEPTS — COMPLETE

THE AKASHIC RECORDS: Blavatsky described a non-physical 'substance' called Akasha (from the Sanskrit term for space or ether) in which every event, thought, and experience that has ever occurred in the universe is permanently recorded. The Akashic Records are the complete history of everything — accessible to sufficiently developed practitioners through specific meditative and psychic techniques. Edgar Cayce's 'Hall of Records' readings, the channeled library accessed by many New Age practitioners, and the contemporary concept of 'accessing the Akashic Records' all derive from this Theosophical concept. **THE ASTRAL PLANE:** Theosophy formalized the concept of the astral plane — a non-physical dimension of existence interpenetrating the physical world, in which thought-forms exist, in which the recently dead initially reside, and to which consciousness can travel in out-of-body experiences, dreams, and meditative states. The astral body — a subtle body coexisting with the physical — is the vehicle through which this travel occurs. This vocabulary became standard in virtually all subsequent Western esoteric traditions. **THE SEVEN PLANES:** Theosophy organized existence into seven interpenetrating planes or dimensions (physical, astral, mental, causal, and three higher spiritual planes) — each with its own inhabitants, its own laws, and its own relationship to human consciousness. This seven-plane framework became the structural basis for much of 20th-century Western occultism. **ROOT RACES:** The most controversial Theosophical concept — Blavatsky described a sequence of seven 'Root Races' of humanity, each corresponding to a different evolutionary stage of human development. The current Root Race is the fifth (the Aryan). This concept was later misappropriated by Nazi ideology, which drew on Theosophical vocabulary while distorting it beyond recognition. Modern Theosophists have generally distanced themselves from the Root Race teachings.

Theosophy → Annie Besant → Alice Bailey → New Age

The lineage from Blavatsky through her successors to the New Age movement is direct and traceable — a transmission of specific concepts and vocabulary that created the spiritual language that hundreds of millions of contemporary practitioners use.

THE TRANSMISSION CHAIN — COMPLETE

ANNIE BESANT (1847-1933): After Blavatsky's death, Annie Besant became the dominant figure in the Theosophical Society. A former atheist and women's rights activist who converted to Theosophy after reviewing *The Secret Doctrine*, Besant expanded the Society's global reach, collaborated with C.W. Leadbeater on clairvoyant investigations that produced detailed maps of the astral plane and descriptions of chakras and subtle bodies, and identified the young Jiddu Krishnamurti as the new World Teacher — a claim Krishnamurti himself eventually rejected. ALICE BAILEY (1880-1949): A student of Theosophy who claimed from 1919 onward to receive dictated teachings from a Tibetan Master called Djwhal Khul. Bailey's 24 volumes of received teachings — published under her own name and 'Djwhal Khul' — systematized the Theosophical cosmology into the most complete and most influential version of the Ascended Master teachings. Bailey introduced the term 'New Age' in its contemporary sense, describing an imminent transition from the Piscean Age to the Aquarian Age that would transform human consciousness. Her influence on the New Age movement is primary and largely unacknowledged. THE NEW AGE MOVEMENT: The New Age movement that emerged in the 1960s-1980s — the crystals, the channeling, the ascended masters, the chakras, the cosmic evolution narrative, the Aquarian Age concept, the recognition of multiple planes of existence — is Theosophy's concepts, simplified, commercialized, and detached from their intellectual apparatus. The direct line from the Fox sisters' rappings to the New Age crystal shop is: Fox sisters → American Spiritualism → Blavatsky/Theosophy → Besant/Bailey → New Age.

Channeling

The New Age Successor to the Séance

Channeling — the New Age term for what Spiritualism called mediumship — is the practice of receiving and transmitting communication from non-physical beings or intelligences through the medium of a human practitioner. The differences between Spiritualist mediumship and New Age channeling are primarily terminological and cosmological rather than practical.

THE MAJOR CHanneled WORKS AND THEIR INFLUENCE

EDGAR CAYCE (1877-1945): The 'Sleeping Prophet' of Virginia Beach — a devout Christian who, from 1901 onward, entered self-induced trances in which he provided medical diagnoses and treatments for patients he had never met, and later (from the 1920s) cosmological readings about past lives, Atlantis, the Akashic Records, and the future. Cayce's readings — over 14,000 of them, recorded by stenographers — constitute one of the largest bodies of channeled material in history. His medical readings are historically significant: many of his diagnoses proved accurate and some of his treatment recommendations anticipated later conventional medical findings. JANE ROBERTS / SETH (1963-1984): Jane Roberts, a housewife and poet from Elmira, New York, began receiving communications in 1963 from an entity identifying itself as Seth — 'an energy personality essence no longer focused in physical reality.' The Seth material (published in multiple volumes through the 1970s) presented a comprehensive metaphysical system: the nature of consciousness, the multidimensional nature of the self, the construction of physical reality through belief and consciousness, and the continuing evolution of the soul across multiple existences. Seth's statement — 'You create your own reality' — became one of the most influential phrases in New Age thought and is a direct ancestor of the Law of Attraction as taught by Abraham-Hicks and popularized by The Secret. ABRAHAM-HICKS: Esther Hicks has channeled the collective intelligence called Abraham since the 1980s. The Abraham teachings — most widely known through the book 'Ask and It Is Given' and the film 'The Secret' — are the most commercially successful channeled material of the contemporary era and represent the most direct line between the Hydesville rappings and the mainstream contemporary spiritual marketplace.

The Haligricity Lens

Ancestor Contact and the Mechanics of Spirit Communication

The Spiritualist Movement offers Haligricity a 175-year documented laboratory of human experience with spirit communication — including both its genuine phenomena and its documented frauds — that illuminates what the tradition holds about the mechanics of ancestor contact and the specific conditions under which spirit communication appears to be possible.

What the Evidence Suggests

The most careful investigators of Spiritualist phenomena — William James, Frederic Myers, Richard Hodgson, Eleanor Sidgwick — consistently found themselves unable to explain certain phenomena through any known conventional mechanism while also finding evidence of fraud in many cases. Their conclusion was not that all Spiritualism was fraud (the evidence prevented this) and not that the survival hypothesis was confirmed (the evidence was insufficient for this), but that something genuine was occurring in at least some cases, and that the genuine phenomenon was worth continued serious investigation. This is a scientifically reasonable conclusion — and it remains the most honest available assessment of the evidence 175 years later.

The Fox sisters asked a dead man to knock. He knocked. The investigators arrived. The scientists arrived. The magicians arrived. The frauds arrived. And through all of it — through every exposure, every confession, every recantation — the phenomenon refused to entirely go away. The Stump at Lily Dale still draws thousands every summer. The mediums still stand and deliver specific information to specific people in the audience about specific deceased individuals. The Akashic Records are still being accessed. Seth's Jane Roberts is still in print. The question is not whether the phenomenon exists — the documented evidence is too consistent for that. The question is what it is. And that question remains open. Grand Rising.

*"The dead have a great deal to say.
The question is not whether they speak.
The question is whether we have made ourselves quiet enough to hear."*

— On the Spiritualist tradition and its 175-year conversation with the other side

Hydesville, 1848. Lily Dale, now. The Fox sisters' house is gone but the community they accidentally started is still there on the shores of Cassadaga Lake, the mediums still standing at the Stump twice a day, delivering the specific information that the specific person in the third row needed to hear about the father who died before they made peace. Blavatsky's Akashic Records became Seth's 'you create your own reality' became Abraham's Law of Attraction. The séance became the private reading. The trumpet became the channeled book. The form changes. The question is the same: is the consciousness that was my beloved still somewhere, and can it hear me? Grand Rising.

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